greater Khurasan and its commercial emporia to the west, or the centrality of Bamiyan as the nodal convergence of east–west and north–south communication routes, the commercial and cultural networks encompassing Ghazna and the region of Zabulistan in general had long been oriented toward the east and India (see Chapters 2 and 3). For Mu'izz al-Din and his loyalists and dependents, then, the conquest of Ghazna in itself was not enough; as had been the case for the Yamini–Ghaznavids before them, the imperial machinery established here could be sustained only if the location was used as a springboard for expanding eastward (see also Chapter 6).

All in all, once again we see that the Shansabani lineages of the 1170s CE would be better understood as a *confederacy* rather than a singular unit, with the three agnatic branches having disparately expanding ambitions (map, p. xv), but nominally subject to overlordship. Although anthropological analysis of modern tribal organizations in Afghanistan is plentiful – perhaps most notably by the "accidental" architectural historians Glatzer and Casimir – the question of confederation has been directly addressed among the Basseri tribe and its larger Khamseh confederacy, their periodic rivals the Qashqai confederacy, and the Bakhtyari tribes – all nomadic pastoralists in south-central Iran. [10] While these studies have highlighted differing circumstances and equally varied processes of confederation, they also underscore confederation as *inherent* to the nomad–urban continuum: kinship-based and other groups tended to come together, that is, confederate, as a response to shifting circumstances, often at the instigation of a leader and his lineage.[11] The Bakhtyari example may provide the most useful parallel to the Shansabanis, as even in regions where imperial presence was not constant or strongly perceptible – certainly the case in Ghur – "confederations form[ed] … in response to an external stimulus – typically, a need for common defense or an opportunity for expansion or conquest".[12]

There are some indications that Mu'izz al-Din only grudgingly acknowledged the seniority of the Firuzkuh branch of Shansabanis.[13] Moreover, Ghiyath al-Din's ambitions of expansion into Khurasan apparently precluded any independent share therein for the Shansabanis at Bamiyan, or for the lately established Ghazna lineage embodied in Mu'izz al-Din, his dependents and military followers. The Ghazna Shansabanis had little choice but to direct their energies toward India. Mu'izz al-Din and his *ghulam*s were now oriented eastward, at least in part swept up in the geo-historical momentum of their predecessors, the Yamini–Ghaznavids. Collectively, Mu'izz al-Din's military successes – and arguably, also his reverses – were to have more palpable, local, and transregional ramifications over the ensuing millennium.